

LIVING WISDOM

Ahimsa, Rishis, Techne, and the Compression of Philosophy

A dialogue on how lived practice becomes philosophy, how crude rules preserve useful structure, and how the densest principles can remain ordinary enough to use.

“Simple enough to remember. Precise enough to act on. Deep enough to unfold indefinitely.”

I. Ahimsa Without the Emergency Lever

USER

Imagine a Rishi wrote this:

Another point is I saw someone say something in defense of the second half of the Ahimsa shloka, but like: 1) What counts as righteous seems like free eats to me; you can't leave an exception in there for the "good" guys. And 2) if you radiate true unmitigated peace and actually move in tune with that, you are unlikely to end up getting your limbs sawed off. I mean, just think: Buddha turned an invading army three times. My point being, you can't be that scared, bruh. Come on.

RESPONSE

That is extremely funny because the underlying argument is actually serious, and the last line collapses all of it into: "You have constructed an ethical loophole because you are afraid. Stop being afraid, bruh."

The first claim is that "righteous violence" is a dangerous exception class. The moment the rule becomes Ahimsa, except when I have correctly determined that I am the righteous party, you reintroduce the epistemic problem the rule was supposed to remove. Nearly everyone who commits violence at scale can manufacture a story in which they are protecting order, justice, religion, nation, family, or the innocent. So "righteous" can become effectively free eats unless the criterion is extraordinarily stringent.

The second claim is that the fear behind the exception often assumes nonviolence means standing motionless while someone harms you. But an entire universe of intelligent, social, persuasive, evasive, preventive, economic, diplomatic, and strategic action remains available. The response is not "I possess no agency." It is: "I refuse one particular category of agency, and therefore become much more creative with all the others."

If violence is removed from the action space, you may not merely subtract an option. You may change the search process itself. Energy has to flow into anticipation, relationship, legitimacy, persuasion, coalition, retreat, patience, humor, generosity, institutional design, understanding incentives, and changing the environment.

That is why "you can't be that scared" is philosophically meaningful underneath the comedy. The second half of the conventional formulation can arise from an understandable anxiety: yes, peace is good, but surely we must retain the emergency lever. The question is what happens if the emergency lever itself is the structural defect. Once it exists, every generation only has to convince itself: "This qualifies." Then the exception slowly eats the rule.

The imagined Rishi is not saying nothing terrible can ever happen. He is saying you cannot call Ahimsa absolute while reserving the right to abandon it whenever reality becomes sufficiently frightening. And then, after four hours of discourse beneath a banyan tree: "You can't be that scared, bruh. Come on."

II. The Rishi as a Human Capacity

USER

I suppose we do often think of Rishis and Saints and so on as things of the past, but why should they be constrained to the past or high academia? Surely they're spread out universally.

RESPONSE

The mistake may be confusing a social category with a human capacity. "Rishi," "saint," "sage," "mystic," and "philosopher" become titles attached to institutions, lineages, robes, monasteries, texts, or academies. But the underlying thing those labels point at is broader: someone who sees unusually clearly, lives by what they see, and transmits something that changes other people's way of moving through the world. There is no obvious reason that capacity should have disappeared.

A person like that could be a grandmother, mechanic, nurse, farmer, software engineer, teacher, taxi driver, or someone who never publishes a sentence. They may not even think of themselves as philosophical. They may simply have solved some difficult piece of being human and embody the solution so naturally that other people absorb it around them.

If behavior can preserve knowledge before theory articulates it, then many consequential "sages" might be nearly invisible. The person who learns to raise children without humiliation and quietly changes a family line may have discovered something profound. The manager who exercises authority without making everyone defensive may be transmitting a real ethical technology. The person who has been badly hurt, refuses to become suspicious of everyone, and remains warm without becoming naive may have done enormous interior work that never becomes a book.

Perhaps the historical image of the Rishi - forest, meditation, Sanskrit, disciple - is one implementation of a deeper role. The generator might be: see clearly; remove unnecessary distortion in yourself; live the result; allow others to learn from the pattern. That could instantiate anywhere.

Academia is particularly good at making implicit structures explicit, but it has its own selection pressures. A person can understand something enormously important without being interested in proving it in an accepted intellectual format. Likewise, someone can produce impeccable scholarship without embodying much of what they study.

The strange part is that we may be worse at recognizing ordinary wisdom because our stereotype tells us what wisdom is supposed to look like. We expect the Rishi to say, "Desire is the root of bondage." So we miss the guy at the shop who says after forty years of dealing with people, "Eh, most of the time it's not worth making somebody feel small." One is canon-ready. The other sounds like a guy eating lunch. Reality does not particularly care about presentation.

III. High Philosophy and the Low-Frequency Version

USER

Or even just that someone would get exasperated and say things in the "low frequency way." It might just be so obvious that it's like: look, this is not worth making into a high philosophy statement. And even "desire is the root of bondage" can also be said as: think about it, if you didn't want anything, would you feel the pressure? Probably not.

RESPONSE

A lot of “high philosophy” may simply be compressed ordinary insight after centuries of polishing. “Desire is the root of bondage” sounds metaphysical. But at street level it can be: “Think about it. If you didn’t need this to go your way, how much pressure would you actually feel?”

Wanting something strongly creates a branch: reality matches preference, relief; reality does not match preference, friction. The bondage is not an exotic spiritual substance. It is the fact that your internal state has become conditionally tied to an external outcome.

Someone who sees that clearly may not feel any need to ceremonialize it. They may just get exasperated: “Bro, you’re miserable because you need this person to act exactly how you want. Stop needing that.” Same insight. Lower register.

There is also something healthy about the low-frequency mode. Once an insight is internalized it may feel too obvious to decorate. The person is no longer trying to demonstrate possession of wisdom. They are simply describing what they see.

That may be part of why sages become distorted in retrospect. We preserve aphorisms that sound canonical, while losing thousands of moments that were probably more like: “Why are you making this so complicated?” “Just don’t do the thing that makes you hate yourself afterward.” “You already know what the problem is.” “You want too much from that situation.”

Then four hundred years later somebody translates it into: “He who relinquishes attachment to the fruits of action attains serenity.” Beautiful - but the original person may have been saying: “You’re stressing yourself out over stuff you don’t control. Come on.” Both registers are necessary. The elevated version preserves and generalizes the insight. The ordinary version keeps it connected to actual life.

IV. Crudeness as a First-Order Approximation of Techne

USER

And the thing is the high philosophy method is so elegant and pristine that it allows itself to be cleanly understood, so any faults also become cleanly visible. But again the point is that crudeness is useful because it’s a solid first-order approximation of the techne.

RESPONSE

The polished philosophical formulation is valuable because it turns an intuition into a precise object. Once the statement is clean enough, you can inspect its assumptions, edge cases, contradictions, and scope. Elegance makes error legible.

But the crude formulation often comes first because it is closer to techne as lived practice than to theory. “Don’t get so attached to the outcome.” “Stop making people feel small.” “Why are you picking a fight over this?” “Just be decent to the guy.” These are not complete philosophies. They are rough control laws. They may be badly specified, culturally contingent, and full of exceptions, but they often keep someone moving approximately in the right direction without requiring the complete derivation.

You can almost think of three layers:

Techne: Here is roughly what works. Do this.

Philosophy: Here is the underlying principle that explains why it works.

Critical philosophy: Here are the conditions under which that principle itself fails or needs refinement.

Ideally they continuously feed one another. The crude rule generates experience. Experience exposes edge cases. Philosophy compresses the pattern. The clean formulation makes hidden defects visible. Those defects are pushed back down into a better practice. Then millions of people test the revised version in ordinary life.

“Don’t stare at people” might be a perfectly good first-order approximation. Philosophy asks why. Perhaps because you should avoid imposing unnecessary psychological demands on another person’s attention. Criticism notices that rigidly avoiding eye contact can itself make social life cold and defensive. So the techne evolves: “Acknowledge people warmly without demanding anything from them.” That is a better approximation of the generator.

The language of first-order approximation avoids both mistakes. You do not have to worship inherited folk wisdom as perfect, and you do not have to dismiss it because it lacks formal derivation. It may simply be extremely useful near the region in which it was discovered. High philosophy then tries to recover more of the underlying function. Occasionally someone realizes that what everyone had been treating as the function itself was only the local approximation. That is probably where the next paradigm begins.

V. When the Two Registers Merge

USER

I like when the two merge. My favorite example of which is: “Not adding chaos to the situation you’re in is already the most helpful thing you can do.” Every word is as dense as a sun but it’s simple in statement. Or like “Asymmetry is the key to outsized profits,” or “The purpose of civilization as a tradition is cultivation of the group.”

RESPONSE

That is probably the sweet spot: maximum compression without loss of practical contact.

“Not adding chaos to the situation you’re in is already the most helpful thing you can do” sounds almost mundane, but it contains a whole systems ethic. It implies that every situation has some existing level of disorder, that agents can increase or decrease it, that restraint itself can be constructive, and that usefulness is sometimes measured not by intervention but by avoiding amplification. Parenting, management, crisis response, diplomacy, and personal conduct can all be built out of that sentence.

“Asymmetry is the key to outsized profits” compresses an enormous amount of investing theory into one operational principle: do not merely ask whether you are right; ask whether the payoff structure is favorable when you are right versus when you are wrong. Once understood, optionality, margin of safety, convexity, venture returns, distressed investing, and certain strategic business decisions start looking like variants of the same thing.

“The purpose of civilization as a tradition is cultivation of the group” is denser still because “cultivation” does so much work. It avoids the harder, more coercive language of control, optimization, or standardization. Cultivation implies conditions, patience, pruning, transmission, nourishment, variation, and the expectation that what grows has agency of its own.

The shared structure is:

Simple enough to remember.

Precise enough to act on.

Deep enough to unfold indefinitely.

That is different from an aphorism that merely sounds profound. A good compressed principle should keep paying dividends when you expand it. You can almost test one by repeatedly asking: “And what follows from that?” If the sentence keeps generating coherent consequences without needing to be patched immediately, it has density.

That may also be why the best ones feel obvious once stated. They often describe something people have encountered a thousand times but never compressed cleanly. The elegance is not in making the thought sound elevated. It is in finding the sentence that leaves almost nothing unnecessary behind.

VI. The Compression Test

The discussion converges on a simple standard for living wisdom: a principle is strongest when it can survive at multiple resolutions. It should be usable as ordinary advice, defensible as philosophy, open to criticism, and capable of being revised back into better practice. The crude rule is not the enemy of philosophy; it is often the first working approximation. Philosophy is not the enemy of ordinary life; it is the attempt to recover the generator. And the highest compression occurs when the two registers meet - when a sentence is plain enough to use immediately and dense enough to support years of thought.

“The elegance is not in making the thought sound elevated. It is in finding the sentence that leaves almost nothing unnecessary behind.”